confiscated properties. In response President Eisenhower closed American markets to Cuban sugar, by far the island's main export.[9]

The United States found itself in a situation akin to the one that the old imperial powers, Britain and France, had faced in their Asian and African colonies and dependencies. There was also the prospect of rising communist and pro-communist movements in Cuba and direct Soviet involvement in the region—a pattern that repeated itself throughout the former colonial world. In April 1959, on a visit to the United States at the invitation of the American Society of Newspaper Editors, Castro made a statement distancing himself from communism. "I know the world thinks of us, we are Communists, and of course I have said very clear that we are not Communists; very clear." But things were changing rapidly. In February 1960, Cuba was visited by one of the top advisers to Nikita Khrushchev, the old Bolshevik and seasoned politician Anastas Mikoyan. He urged his boss in Moscow to provide economic assistance to the young revolutionary regime. In May, Khrushchev made a public statement threatening the United States with nuclear arms over Cuban independence. It was the Monroe Doctrine in reverse. The Soviet Union was prepared to protect the independence of Latin American countries from the United States.

As far as Eisenhower was concerned, American interests were at stake, and communism was on the march in Cuba, whether Castro was a communist or not. Luckily, the president's advisers had a plan to deal with the crisis. Only a few years earlier, in June 1954, the CIA had executed a successful coup in Guatemala, where land reform threatened the interests of the United Fruit Company. In March 1960, with agrarian reform in Cuba already underway but confiscation of American commercial properties not yet announced, Eisenhower decided to bring about regime change in Cuba. Castro was to be removed from power in the same way he had acquired it: through a popular uprising initiated by political exiles returning to Cuba. The CIA prepared a plan, but Eisenhower did not have time to carry out the project. It was passed on instead to the new president, John Kennedy.[10]

◊◊◊